

Before 1920

A period of intense activity in the study of aerodynamics began in the 1880s. Daring pioneers designed gliders made of little more than wood and canvas and risked their lives to further our knowledge of flight. Louis Blériot's cross-Channel flight of 1909 was made in a simple monoplane with a three-cylinder engine and stick-and-rudder controls of the type still used today. World War I forced a fast rate of development, leading to more robust and maneuverable airplanes.

